

Homework 5. Due by 11:59pm on Sunday 10/11.

Conflicts of interest and conflicts of commitment

Conflicts of interest (COI) and conflicts of commitment (COC) are a central topic for maintaining responsible scientific conduct since failure to manage COI/COC situations can lead to irresponsible conduct. Read pages 43–47 of *On Being a Scientist*. Write brief answers to the following questions, by editing the tex file available at <https://github.com/ionides/810f26>, and submit the resulting pdf file via Canvas.

1. What is the difference between a conflict of interest and a conflict of commitments? Sometimes people group together COI/COC to avoid the need to distinguish between these somewhat similar concepts. Discuss a situation that might be hard to classify, and explain whether you think it is best described as a COI or COC. Ideally, incorporate personal experience into your example. Do not pick the need to balance teaching and research, since that is addressed below. Hint: how does the classification between COI and COC relate to the aphorism “time is money.”

YOUR ANSWER HERE

2. Give an example of a conflict of interest that you have seen or heard about in an academic mentor/mentee relationship. Your answer should address the meaning of “interest” in the RCRS sense (see Homework 1).

YOUR ANSWER HERE

3. You are asked to review a paper for a leading journal. You have high professional respect for the first author, and the paper looks interesting to you. You also count this author among your personal friends, meaning you meet up at conferences and occasionally chat about work and life at other times. Can you responsibly agree to review the paper? Imagine you are giving advice to another friend who is in this situation.

YOUR ANSWER HERE

4. Most PhD students have to balance time allocated to teaching (GSI) duties with their thesis research. Is this a conflict of interest, or a conflict of commitment, or both, or neither? What is your personal experience of this balance? If you don’t have experience as a GSI, you can comment on how your own instructors have balanced teaching with research.

YOUR ANSWER HERE

5. The two main ways to manage conflicts of interest are transparency and avoidance. Give an example of a conflict of interest that you have seen or heard about that is best managed by avoidance and another best managed by transparency.

YOUR ANSWER HERE